

YOUR HABITS SHAPE YOUR FUTURE

The Power of Habits – how small actions lead to big results

Have you ever noticed that some things you do every day feel completely **automatic**? You wake up, brush your teeth, and pack your school bag without really thinking about it. These are habits – actions that have become so **routine** that your brain carries out the task without much **conscious** effort. But habits are not just about the small things in life. According to researchers, nearly half of everything we do each day is the result of a habit rather than a deliberate decision. That means your habits have an enormous influence on who you are and who you are becoming.

Charles Duhigg, an author and journalist who has written extensively about human behaviour, explains that every habit follows a simple three-part **loop**: a **cue**, a **routine**, and a **reward**. Understanding this loop is the first step towards taking control of your habits and using them to improve your life. So, what kind of habits do you have? Consider these situations:

1 You sit down to study, but you immediately pick up your phone. What do you do?

a I scroll through social media for a while before I start – it helps me relax.

b I put my phone in another room so I can concentrate on my work straight away.

2 You want to build up a new habit, like reading every evening. What do you do?

a I try hard for a few days but then forget about it when things get busy.

b I set a specific time each evening and stick to it, even if it's only ten minutes.

These situations illustrate how habits work in real life. People who struggle to **stick to** new behaviours often rely on **willpower** alone. But research shows that willpower is limited – it runs out, especially when we are tired or stressed. People who successfully build good habits tend to use a different approach: they design their environment and **routine** so that the right action becomes the easy one.

WEAK HABIT BUILDERS ...

- rely on **willpower** to get things done.
- set vague goals without a clear **routine** or **trigger**.
- give up quickly after missing a day or making a mistake.
- focus on **short-term** comfort rather than **long-term** progress.
- try to change too many things at once and feel overwhelmed.

STRONG HABIT BUILDERS ...

- design their environment to make good habits **automatic**.
- use a clear **cue** and **reward** to **reinforce** new behaviours.
- **track** their **progress** and **reflect** on what is working.
- focus on building **consistency** rather than perfection.
- start small and **build up** gradually over time.

Did you know that habits are stored in a part of the brain called the basal ganglia? When you repeat an action enough times, the brain begins to **carry out** that action automatically, without needing you to think about it consciously. This is actually a very efficient system – it frees up your brain to focus on new and more complex tasks. The problem is that this process works just as well for bad habits as it does for good ones.

So how do you **break a habit** you no longer want? Experts suggest that the most effective approach is not to simply try to stop the behaviour, but to **replace** it with a different **routine** that uses the same **cue** and delivers a similar **reward**. For example, if your **trigger** for eating unhealthy snacks is feeling bored, you could replace the snack with a short walk or a glass of water. Over time, the new routine becomes just as **automatic** as the old one.

One of the most powerful ideas in habit research is the concept of **identity**. James Clear, the author of the bestselling book *Atomic Habits*, argues that the most effective way to change your behaviour is to change the way you see yourself. Instead of saying 'I want to read more books', try saying 'I am a reader'. When your habits become part of your identity, they are much easier to **stick to** because every time you **carry out** the habit, you are proving to yourself who you are.

Another key idea is the importance of making habits small enough to start. Many people set goals that are too ambitious and then feel discouraged when they cannot keep them up. Instead, try starting with something so simple that it feels almost too easy. Want to **build up** an exercise habit? Start with just five minutes a day. Want to improve your English? Commit to learning three new words each morning. Small actions, when done with **consistency**, lead to remarkable **long-term** results.

It is also essential to **track** your habits and **reflect** on your **progress** regularly. Keeping a simple habit tracker – even just ticking a box in a notebook each day – gives you a visual record of your **consistency** and makes you less likely to give up. Research shows that seeing a chain of successful days builds momentum and makes you want to continue. And if you do miss a day, the most important rule is this: never miss twice. One missed day is an accident; two missed days is the start of a new habit going in the wrong direction.

Finally, remember that building good habits is not about being perfect – it is about making **progress**. Every time you act in line with your **intention**, no matter how small the action, you are casting a vote for the kind of person you want to become. Your habits are not just things you do. They are a reflection of who you are – and who you are choosing to be.

ACTIVITIES

3

Read the article again and answer the questions.

- 1 What three parts make up a habit loop, according to Charles Duhigg?
- 2 Why does willpower alone often fail when building new habits?
- 3 What part of the brain stores habits?
- 4 What does James Clear suggest about identity and habits?
- 5 What should you do if you miss a day of your new habit?

4

Match the highlighted words and phrases in the article to the meanings. Then write one sentence for each.

- 1 done without thinking
- 2 a signal that starts a habit
- 3 doing something regularly over time
- 4 to stop doing a habit
- 5 a goal you want to achieve

5

Read the extension section of the article and answer the questions.

- 1 What does James Clear mean by 'identity-based habits'?
- 2 Why does the article suggest starting with very small habits?
- 3 What is a 'habit tracker' and how does it help?
- 4 What is the most important rule if you miss a day?

6

Think of one habit you would like to build or break. Write a short plan using ideas from the article.

Use these prompts to help you:

My cue will be ... / My routine will be ... / My reward will be ... / I will track my progress by ...

■ TALKING POINTS

Do you think it is easier to build a new habit or break an old one? Why?

Which of your current habits has the biggest positive effect on your studies?

Do you agree that your habits reflect your identity? Give an example.

Is it ever too late to change your habits? Why / Why not?